



USA THREAT TO PAKISTAN

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPED /
DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS



Learning Space

LIVE



NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

4th JANUARY, 2018

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Trump threatens to cut Pak aid, but Pak also has an ace or two up its sleeve

The US and its allies have been in a tug-of-war over how to deal with Pakistan's role in the US-led war in Afghanistan. The US has threatened to withhold all assistance to the US-led coalition forces in Afghanistan unless they withdraw all troops from the country by the end of 2017. Pakistan's response has been to threaten to cut off US aid to the coalition forces in Afghanistan.



President-elect Donald Trump with other officials in front of a black SUV.

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Money talks

Pakistan is worried less by U.S. withdrawal of aid than the overall downside in ties

That the U.S. will continue to withhold \$255 million in Foreign Military Financing to Pakistan this year suggests it is prepared to downgrade its ties with Pakistan further in an effort to hold it to account on terrorism. U.S. Ambassador to the UN Nikki Haley cited Pakistan's "double game" of cooperating with the U.S. and harbouring terrorists who attack its troops in Afghanistan. Mr. Trump's own tweet, a day earlier, on January 1, was less temperate in its wording. He accused Pakistan of "lies and deceit" and of treating the U.S. leadership as "fools". Pakistan has reacted, but without the same heat in its words. After a National Security Council meeting of top generals and ministers convened by Prime Minister Shahid Khaqan Abbasi, it issued a statement expressing "disappointment" over the U.S. statements, and referring to Pakistan's record in fighting terrorism and providing support to the U.S. effort in Afghanistan. One reason is that the U.S. decision to hold back the \$255 million was not unexpected. In May last year, the Trump administration had decided to cut the annual outlay for 2018 from \$255 million to \$100 million. In August, it notified Congress it would withhold the current tranche due for 2016 as well, while a decision on 2017 was still pending. Second, while the overall downside in ties with the U.S. will be a major worry for Pakistan, the cancellation of funds may not be that alarming. American assistance to Pakistan is at its lowest levels since 2001. Third, Pakistan's confidence that it has an alternative in China has grown, with Beijing's pledge of more than \$100 billion in loans for the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor infrastructure, power projects, and so on. The question, then, is whether the U.S. will consider stronger measures, such as stopping all funding, sanctions, or cancelling Pakistan's "major non-NATO ally" status.

From India's point of view, any attempt to hold Pakistan's feet to the fire on its support to terror groups is a positive development. It is particularly important that the U.S. follow through on its ultimatums in this respect. However, all American statements so far focus on Pakistan's support to terror groups that threaten Afghanistan, and more particularly, the U.S. troops in Afghanistan. Therefore, action against the groups that threaten India is unlikely to be an immediate priority. New Delhi must also be mindful of the impact of a more fractured U.S.-Pakistan relationship on regional security. Above all, the U.S.-Pakistan relationship, like that between India and the U.S. and India and Pakistan, is a long-standing bilateral one. While welcoming all moves to address India's core concerns on terror, New Delhi must ensure it doesn't get ensnared or triangulated in the equation between Washington and Islamabad.

1 Trump threatens to cut Pak aid

The US aid cut threat, however, is not new. Nor has Pakistan failed to threaten the US in return, as it did when it blockaded all movement of US and NATO trucks for seven months from November 2011-July 2012, after 24 Pakistani soldiers were killed in an US raid.

US President Donald Trump's first tweet of 2018, accusing Pakistan of "lies and deceit" and giving "safe haven to terrorists we hunt in Afghanistan" may bring smiles of vindication to the Modi government, but it might be wise to hold off the bubbly and see how things unfold, especially if the past is any guide to the complex US-Pakistan relationship.

Over the weekend, the 'New York Times' reported that the Trump administration was "contemplating withholding" \$225 million in aid meant for military training and equipment to Pakistan, if it didn't hand over a Haqqani Network operative who kidnapped an American-Canadian couple and held them hostage for close to five years.

According to US sources, Pakistan is displaying a "non-serious attitude" to its request. The US Defence secretary needs to regularly certify to Congress that Pakistan regularly takes proper action against the Haqqani Network, a terror group which has been accused of killing an Indian diplomat, an Indian defence attaché and several Indian civilians in Afghanistan. But if Pakistan refuses to accede to the latest US demand, the US could withhold that money.

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It was only after then US Secretary of State Hilary Clinton apologized for the raid that the Pakistanis lifted the blockade. The US administration, from Obama to Trump, have tried several times to bring their chief ally in the war against terror to heel. In 2015, it cut \$300 million from the Coalition Support Fund, in 2016 that amount was increased to \$350 million and in 2017, it went up to \$400 million.

The proposed cut for 2018 is \$350 million. The withheld amount stays in an escrow account, but Pakistan can technically claim the money within two years.

Since 2015, however, the US Defence secretary has refused to grant Pakistan a certificate of clean health, meaning, the US believes that Pakistan regularly plays a double game in its conduct in the war against terror – gets paid by the US to provide access to Afghanistan, but refuses to shut down its terror havens inside Pakistan.

The US wants Pakistan to not only shut down those terror havens, but use its influence on those terror organisations to come to the talks table with the Afghan government so that elections can be held peaceably later this year.

In addition to CSF monies, Pakistan also gets aid under Foreign Military Financing (FMF) – it received \$265 million in 2015, \$225 million in 2016 and another \$225 million in 2017.

The money for 2017 has been approved by the US Congress, but according to the NYT report, US officials have told Pakistan that it will not release the money unless Pakistan takes strong action under Trump's new strategy on Afghanistan-Pakistan.

1 Trump threatens to cut Pak aid

It is in this context that Donald Trump tweeted his first tweet of January 18 :

“The United States has foolishly given Pakistan more than 33 billion dollars in aid over the last 15 years, and they have given us nothing but lies & deceit, thinking of our leaders as fools. They give safe haven to the terrorists we hunt in Afghanistan, with little help. No more!”

Trump's New Year tweet has certainly caused a great deal of consternation inside Pakistan. Many analysts are cautioning the establishment not to react too angrily, warning of the possibility of another “Abbottabad,” a reference to the US air raid in May 2012, when Osama bin Laden was plucked out of his hide-out in full view of the Pakistan military academy barely two hours from Islamabad.

Some others, like Nasim Zehra, are crying out to teach the US a lesson :

“When PPP was in power Pakistan took an honourable position when US attacked the Salala post – heavens did not fall. Pak discontinued US access to Afghanistan via Pak . Finally US apologised for the attack. This excessively rude man Trump must apologise,” Zehra said.

Pakistan prime minister Shahid Khaqan Abbasi is chairing a high-level National Security Council meeting this evening to listen to all sides, including the military, before Islamabad puts out an official response.

If Pakistan, already caught up in a gathering civil-military crisis for most of 2017, decides to take tough action, then the region will likely get even more troubled than it has been in recent years.

Certainly, the Afghans are thrilled. Amrullah Saleh, former Afghan national security advisor, tweeted :

1 Trump threatens to cut Pak aid

Dear Pakistani Establishment: President Trump is neither Indian or Afghan nor R&AW or NDS or Northern Alliance . He is the US president & has acknowledged the truth that Pakistan is a State sponsoring terrorism. Think of a new narrative & strategy as the old one has faltered.

And again :

US President @POTUS has just acknowledged the very obvious truth which we all knew for years. It was always puzzling for us as to why US tolerates such level of deceit.

For a change, the 'New York Times' and Trump are on the same page. On Christmas Day, the 'Times' rapped Pakistan on the knuckles saying that as "terrorism claims new civilian victims and the army uses Islamist extremists to stage what has all the hallmarks of a velvet coup."

It went on to add :

The real catastrophe in Pakistan is the cynical use of Islamist extremism by the country's security establishment to hold democracy hostage and to foment the insecurity it needs to maintain its grip on power. Until that changes, there is scant hope Pakistan will take control of the terrorism that threatens its citizens' lives and the stability of the region." On the face of it, India will be pleased that the world's most powerful country, the US, is coming down so hard on its hostile neighbor in its west. But India will be prepared for the fact that Pakistan will reach out even more to its benefactor and "iron brother" China to alleviate the economic hardship a potential US crackdown on Pakistan. It is unclear what the US will do, but the signs have been there for some time. Trump had fired the first salvo as long ago as August 2017 when he reminded Islamabad of its "obligations" to help America "because it receives massive payments" from Washington every year.

1 Trump threatens to cut Pak aid

“We have made clear to Pakistan that while we desire continued partnership, we must see decisive action against terrorist groups operating on their territory. And we make massive payments every year to Pakistan. They have to help,” the US president had said at the time.

Soon after in December, a Pentagon report said the US would take “unilateral steps” in areas of divergence with Pakistan. Visiting Bagram airbase in Afghanistan on December 22, US Vice-President Mike Pence said Trump had “put Pakistan on notice”.

1 Money talks

Pakistan is worried less by U.S. withdrawal of aid than the overall downslide in ties. That the U.S. will continue to withhold \$255 million in [Foreign Military Financing to Pakistan](#) this year suggests it is prepared to downgrade its ties with Pakistan further in an effort to hold it to account on terrorism. U.S. Ambassador to the UN Nikki Haley cited Pakistan's "double game" of cooperating with the U.S. and harbouring terrorists who attack its troops in Afghanistan. Mr. Trump's own tweet, a day earlier, on January 1, was less temperate in its wording. He [accused Pakistan of "lies and deceit"](#) and of treating the U.S. leadership as "fools". Pakistan has reacted, but without the same heat in its words. After a National Security Council meeting of top generals and ministers convened by Prime Minister Shahid Khaqan Abbasi, it issued a statement expressing "disappointment" over the U.S. statements, and referring to Pakistan's record in fighting terrorism and providing support to the U.S. effort in Afghanistan. One reason is that the U.S. decision to hold back the \$255 million was not unexpected. In May last year, the Trump administration had decided to cut the annual outlay for 2018 from \$255 million to \$100 million. In August, it notified Congress it would withhold the current tranche due for 2016 as well, while a decision on 2017 was still pending. Second, while the overall downslide in ties with the U.S. will be a major worry for Pakistan, the cancellation of funds may not be that alarming. American assistance to Pakistan is at its lowest levels since 2001. Third, Pakistan's confidence that it has an alternative in China has grown, with Beijing's pledge of more than \$100 billion in loans for the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor infrastructure, power projects, and so on. The question, then, is whether the U.S. will consider stronger measures, such as stopping all funding, sanctions, or cancelling Pakistan's 'major non-NATO ally' status.

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From India's point of view, any attempt to hold Pakistan's feet to the fire on its support to terror groups is a positive development. It is particularly important that the U.S. follow through on its ultimatums in this respect. However, all American statements so far focus on Pakistan's support to terror groups that threaten Afghanistan, and more particularly, the U.S. troops in Afghanistan. Therefore, action against the groups that threaten India is unlikely to be an immediate priority. New Delhi must also be mindful of the impact of a more fractured U.S.-[Pakistan](#) relationship on regional security. Above all, the U.S.-Pakistan relationship, like that between India and the U.S. and India and Pakistan, is a long-standing bilateral one. While welcoming all moves to address India's core concerns on terror, New Delhi must ensure it doesn't get ensnared or triangulated in the equation between Washington and Islamabad.

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DONALD TRUMP



NEWS REPORT

- President of USA threatened to stop aid to Pakistan.
- USA has given Pakistan more than \$ 33.9 billion in aid over the last 15 years.
- He stated that they have given us nothing but lies and deceit, thinking of our leaders as fools.
- They give safe haven to the terrorists we hunt in Afghanistan, with little help.





**ALASKA
USA**

CANADA

UNITED STATES

North
Pacific
Ocean

Caribbean Sea



BARACK OBAMA
FORMER PRESIDENT, USA



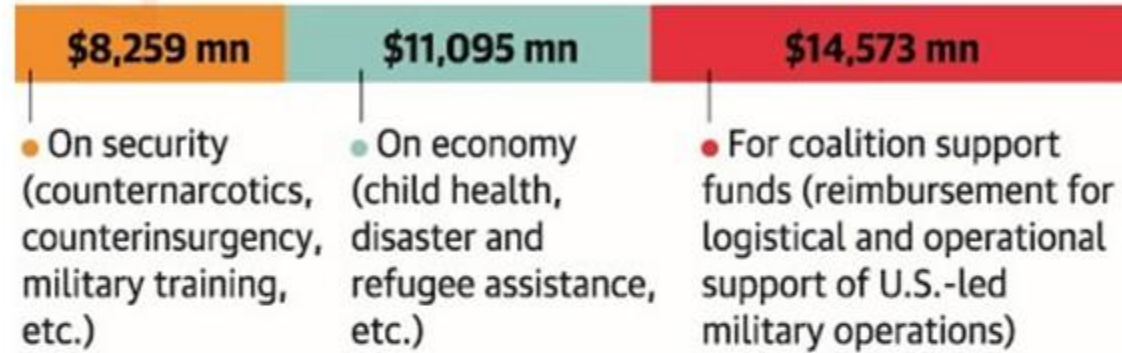
DONALD TRUMP
PRESIDENT, USA

WHAT WERE PREVIOUS SUCH INSTANCES?

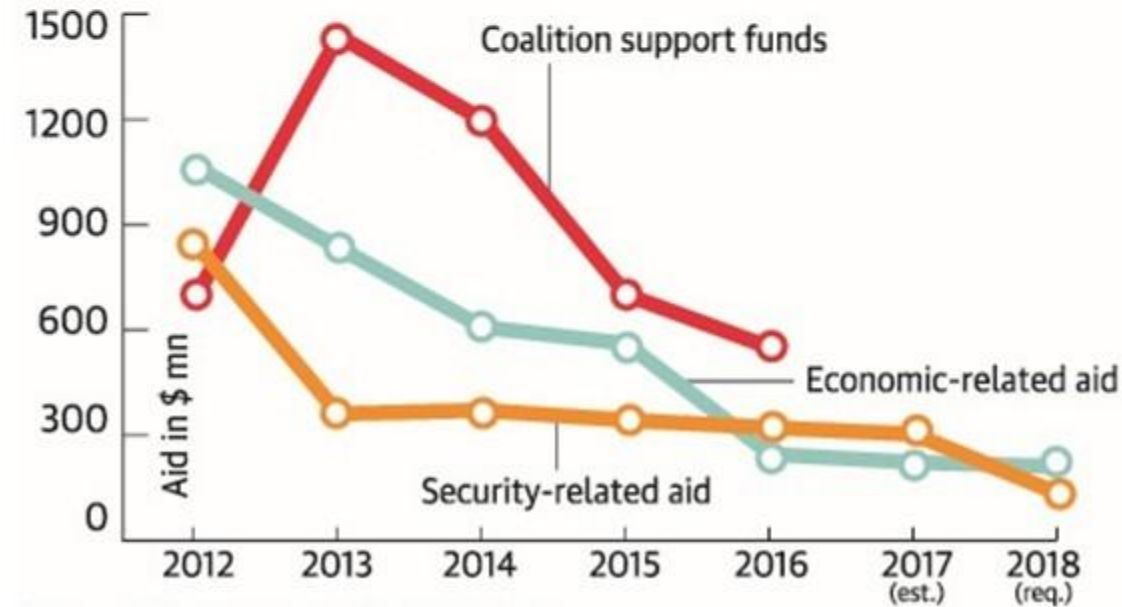
- 1 USA tried several times to make Pakistan listen to them by cutting the aid.
- 2 In 2015, it cut \$ 300 million from the Coalition Support Fund. In 2016, that amount increased to \$ 350 million and in 2017, it went up to \$ 400 million.

In 2018, the proposed cut is \$ 350 million. The withheld amount will go to the escrow account, but Pakistan can technically claim the money within two years.

TYPE OF MONEY PAKISTAN GETS FROM USA



But the amount has come down in recent years



Source: Federation of American Scientists (FAS)



SEE THE CASE OF OSAMA BIN LADEN!

- 1 The double role of Pakistan is quite evident and this is one clear example.
- 2 The Abbottabad attack in May 2011, through an air raid killed Osama Bin Laden, the founder and head of the Islamist group Al-Qaeda.
- 3 This is in full view of the Pakistan Military Academy.



DEEP STATE

Organizations such as military, police, or political groups that are said to work secretly in order to protect particular interests and to rule a country without being elected.

THE REAL PROBLEM IS PAKISTANI MILITARY

- 1 Pakistani Military uses Islamist extremism.
- 2 This is to foment insecurity to maintain grip on power.
- 3 The deep state in Pakistan is mainly responsible for the problems, whether it is faced by India or Afghanistan or USA.

PAKISTAN IS NON-SERIOUS, FEELS USA



- 1 Pakistan is displaying a non-serious attitude.
- 2 U.S. Defence Secretary has to regularly certify to The Congress that Pakistan regularly takes proper action against the Haqqani Network, a terror group.
- 3 Haqqani Network is accused of killing an Indian Diplomat, an Indian Defence attaché and several Indian civilians in Afghanistan.
- 4 But if Pakistan refuses to accede to the latest US demand, the US could withhold that money.



WHAT IT MEANS TO PAKISTAN?

- Millions of dollars of aid is nothing in comparison to the billions of dollars of investments (the consequences of debt will be known only after sometime)
- The “iron brother”, China may come to the rescue of Pakistan.
- However, Pakistan may not go against USA at this juncture.



MONGOLIA

CHINA

Sea of Japan

North Korea

South Korea

JAPAN

East China Sea

NEPAL

INDIA

MYANMAR
(BURMA)

VIETNAM

Lao PDR

BANGLADESH

KAZAKHSTAN

KYRGYZSTAN

TAJIKISTAN

AFGHANISTAN

PAKISTAN



WHY SUCH PARTISAN ATTITUDE?

- 1** Whether U.S. will consider stronger measures, such as stopping all the funding, sanctions or cancelling Pakistan's "major non-NATO ally" status remains to be same.
- 2** U.S. gives ultimatums only with regard to the focus of Pakistan support to terror groups that threaten Afghanistan, especially U.S. troops in Afghanistan.
- 3** But, it never bothers about the groups which threaten India.

We should also look at the issue with regard to the impact of a more fractured U.S. - Pakistan relationship on regional security.

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